

First Baptist Church



1942 - 1992

Tehachapi, California

**50TH ANNIVERSARY
1942 - 1992**

DECEMBER 6, 1992

**FIRST BAPTIST CHURCH
1049 SOUTH CURRY
TEHACHAPI, CA 93561**

CHARTER MEMBERS - DECEMBER 17, 1942

**Olin Collier
Vera Collier
Bobby Collier
Frank Collier
Everett Sims
Ada Lee Sims
Bert McLaughlin
Ada Lee McLaughlin
Minnie Love
Cleo Green
George Johnson
Mahata Johnson**

**"Upon this Rock I will build My
Church, and the gates of Hell
shall not prevail against it."**

Matthew 16:18



Charter Members
First Baptist Church

George and Mahota Johnson Everett and Adalee Sims Minnie Love Bert McLaughlin

On the following page in the order that they appear are Olin and Vera Collier
Frank and Bob Collier Adalee McLaughlin and Cleo Green



PASTORS OF THE FIRST BAPTIST CHURCH TEHACHAPI, CALIFORNIA

F.E. Dick Loving	1942 - 1943
R.E. Cure	1943 - 1944
John O. Hux	1945 - 1945
Dave Chamblin	1945 - 1946
John L. Alexander	1946 - 1948
Homer D. Wilkes	1948 - 1950
T. Gordon Seibold	1950 - 1953
R.N. Blackwood	1954 - 1955
George Findley	1955 - 1962
R. Keith Lloyd	1962 - 1965
Raymond Robertson	1965 - 1971
Dexter Ogan	1972 - 1982
Phil Neighbors	1983 - 1985
Mike Chaney	1984 - 1985
James Trammell	1986 - 1988
Jerry McCullah	1988 - ????

**".....and how shall they believe in Him of
whom they have not heard? And how
shall they hear without a preacher?"**

Romans 10:14

PASTORS OF FIRST BAPTIST
CHURCH TEHACHAPI CALIF.



F.E. Loving
1942 - 43



R.E. Cure
1943 - 44

J. O. Hux
1945 - 45

picture not
available



Dave Chamblin
1945 - 46



T. Gordon Seibold
1950 - 53

R. N. Blackwood
1954 - 55
picture not
available



John L. Alexander

1946 - 48



George Findley

1955 - 62



Raymond Robertson

1965 - 71



Homer D. Wilkes

1948 - 50

picture not
available

R. Keith Lloyd

1962 - 65

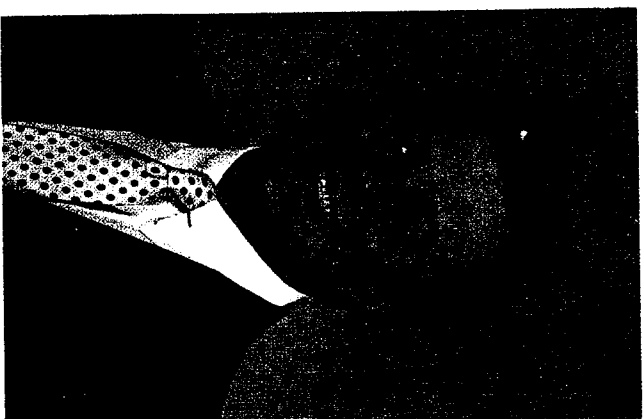


Dexter Ogan

1972 - 82



Phil Neighbors
1983 - 85



Mike Chaney
1984 - 85



James Trammell
1986 - 87



Jerry McCullah
1988 -



Tom Allred
Twin Oaks Mission
Pastor



Ruben Viveros
Spanish Mission
Pastor

IN THE BEGINNING - 1942-1953

By Ada Lee McLaughlin



The First Baptist Church of Tehachapi came into being as a direct answer to the prayers of a frail, little gentlewoman suffering from cancer, Mrs. Lee T. Holland, who was a native of Texas. She had seen a Northern Baptist Church organized in this town only to die in a few short months because of an agreement between the Northern Baptist Convention and the congregational Denomination. However, she never ceased to pray that she would live to see a Southern Baptist Church established in Tehachapi; and because of her faith, some six of us women were inspired to organize a Woman's Missionary Society in the spring of 1942. We met weekly at the home of Mrs. Minnie Love, our president. We subscribed to the woman's magazine, Royal Service, and as best we knew how, tried to carry out the South-wide program of our denomination.

In a few months the fellowship we Baptists were worshipping with launched a building program; and feeling we could not support such a move financially, we decided to meet one Sunday afternoon at Mrs. Love's and organize a Sunday School. This we did with \$22.00 present and a \$18.00 collection. We wrote to the Home Mission Board for advice and aid, but were advised they had no funds or aid for

California Missions. They did suggest that we order literature from the Sunday School Board, free for the first quarter. This we did.

We were a little chagrined, but undaunted. The Colliers were sure the Missouri Convention would help, the Sims and Mrs. Love were just as positive that Texas would help, and the McLaughlins knew Oklahoma could definitely be counted on. However, all three states had troubles of their own and expressed regret that no help could be given.

Nevertheless, we rented a meeting place under the Juanita Hotel for \$25.00 a month, bought 20 chairs from the congregational Community Church, a used piano from Phillips Music Store in Bakersfield, and with 25 song books and a communion set left by the defunct Northern Baptist church, we were now in business for our Lord.

Writing to Brother G.F. Loving, then Pastor of First Southern Baptist Church in Bakersfield for information regarding someone to preach for us, he sent his brother, Brother Dick Loving, who in turn arranged for a group of ministers and deacons of the San Joaquin Valley Association to meet with us for the purpose of organizing a Southern Baptist Church in Tehachapi. It was a most serious undertaking; but on December 17, 1942, eight of us with letters in hand, promised the Lord we would, to the best of our ability, through faith in Him, constitute and support His church in this community. The eight were: Mr. and Mrs. Olin Collier and son Bobby, Mr. and Mrs. Everett Sims, Mrs. Minnie Love and Mr. and Mrs. Bert McLaughlin.

The first act of the new church was to vote to give 3% of undesignated funds to the cooperative program and to raise the percentage to 10% as soon as possible. We were not long in giving the 10%. Brother F.E. (Dick) Loving was called as pastor. He was paid \$10.00 per Sunday since he did not live on the field. The church voted to hold the charter open for 60 days, until February 17, 1943. Within this period, we witnessed the first conversion, that of Frank Collier, second son of Olin and Vera Collier. George Johnson and Mrs. L.A. Green united on promise of letters and Mrs. George Johnson came as a candidate for baptism.

Our two candidates were baptized at First Southern Baptist in Bakersfield by Brother Freeman due to our pastor's physical condition. Thus our membership was 12 when the charter closed.

Our country was at war with Japan at this time, and most of us had sons, grandsons or brothers that were in the Armed Services. The women made a silk prayer flag--white ground bordered in red with a blue star placed on the white for each service man for whom we pledged to pray at a regular time each Sunday morning. The flag with 19 stars on it was unveiled on Easter Sunday with a relative of the serviceman removing the cover over his star and standing to offer silent prayer for him. It was an impressive service, and many people in Tehachapi who never attended any church service asked that we put a star on the flag for their loved one. Between 25 and 35 stars were finally on it and we praise God that not one of the blue stars turned to gold.

On that Easter Sunday, our dear Mrs. Holland was privileged to attend our service and unite with the church. The year she was spared to worship with us was one of great inspiration to all who knew her.

On our first birthday we had 21 members, 36 enrolled in Sunday School--average attendance of 31, 16 enrolled in Training Union--average attendance of 23 and a new pastor coming on the field, Brother R.E. Cure. Brother Loving had resigned on account of ill health.

In 1944, 34 members came into our fellowship; among them Mr. and Mrs. Lee Pinley; Mr. and Mrs. Simon Gilliland and three children, Jimmy, Gene and Lois; Lenna Johnson; Joann McLaughlin and Delmar Green. We had outgrown our meeting place, and we were fighting the devil on his own ground in a building called the "Hut." Some of our Sunday School classrooms were furnished with booths from another barroom. On our second birthday, we were pastorless and our membership was 49.

There are many points of interest in our history, but time doesn't permit our enumerating them. A lot was purchased during our early years, and later sold and the money applied to the purchase price of the ground on which our buildings are located. This property was purchased from L.J. Kanstein for \$1,600.00. He then made a gift to us of \$500.00. Brother Dave Chamblin, our 4th pastor, led in the purchase of lumber from the government from which the pastorium was built. Surplus lumber and materials were sold to pay off indebtedness and build the first unit of the present church building. Brother Chamblin resigned before the pastorium was completed to enroll in Golden Gate Seminary.

Brother D.D. Talley of Fresno led in a 2 week revival. He was evangelist by night and was head carpenter by day in erecting the first unit of our place of worship at 414 S. Curry Street. In 1950, T. Gordon Siebold became our 7th pastor. The East Wing was added to the church unit after his arrival.

Our first Vacation Bible School was held in 1944, and with the exception of two summers, one has been held each year since. One year two mission schools were held--one at Monoilth and one at Keene. The largest school was held in 1959 with an enrollment of 219.

During these first ten years, six men were set apart by the church and ordained to the diaconship: Everett Sims, Simon Gilliland, Bert McLaughlin, George Johnson, Olin Collier and LeRoy Renfro. God laid His hand on two of our men to preach His gospel--Brother B.H. McAllister and Brother Olin Collier.

The Mojave Church was organized from a mission sponsored by the Tehachapi Church, with ten members going to compose it. The recently organized church in Lancaster was also a part of our mission program. Our church was one of the churches which composed the organization of the Mojave Desert Association in 1947.

Such men as B.N. Lummis, R.W. Lackey, John O. Scott, Dr. Craighead, Dr. Jacob Gartenhaus, Dr. Ervin Cole, Brother Fred DeBerry, Brother Bucknew, Brother

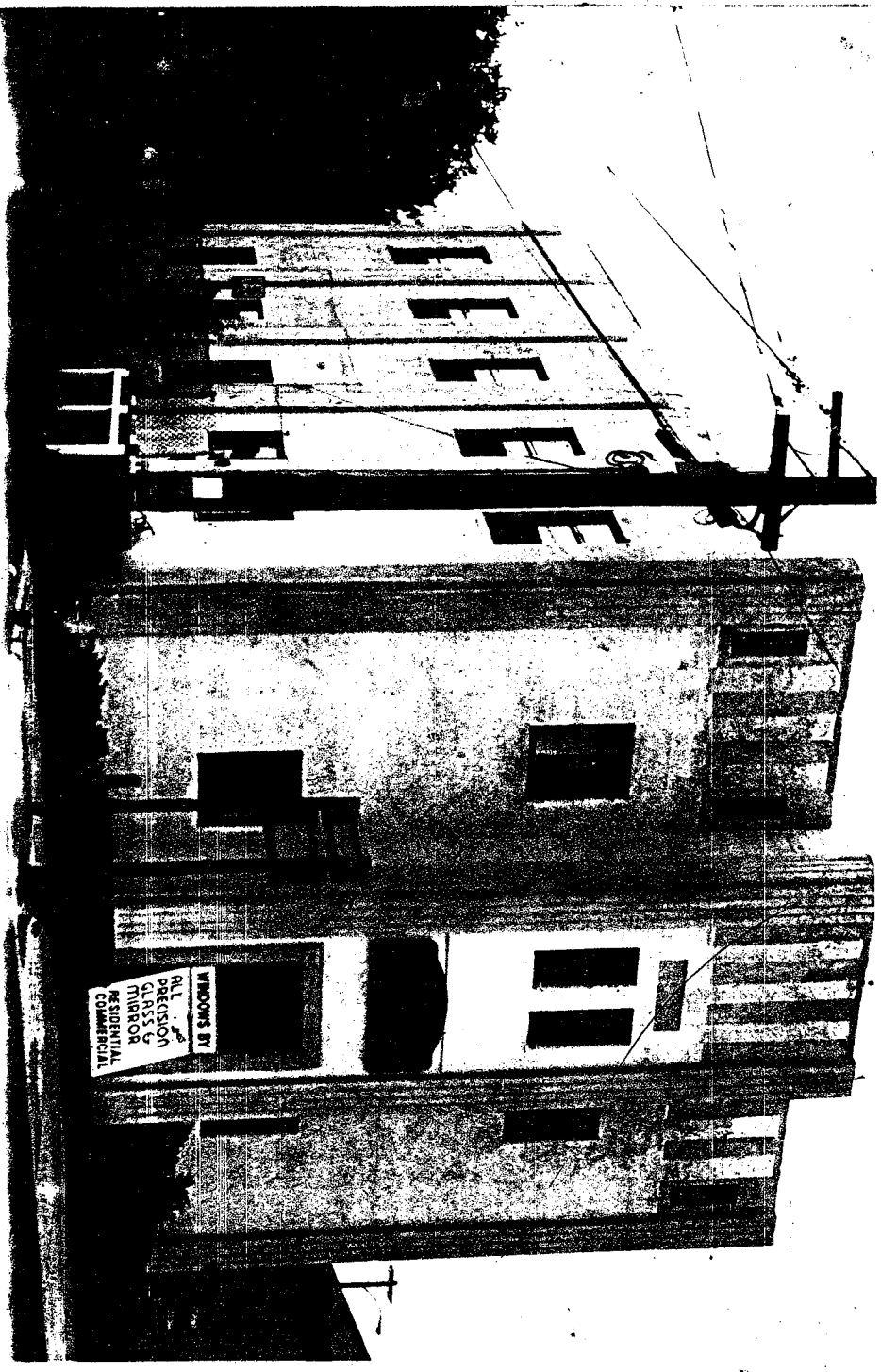
J.V. Dawes, Dr. Crittendon, Dr. B.O. Herring, Dr. Phelps, Brother A.C. Turner and our present Executive Secretary, Dr. S.G. Posey, have preached from our pulpit and each has contributed much to our spiritual welfare.

Our beloved dead have been Mrs. Lee T. Holland, Brother Gandy and Mrs. May Wills.

The slogan of, "Debt Free by '53" was adopted early in 1952 when our debt was nearly \$1,000.00. Late September found us with more than half the amount yet unpaid, when a check for \$600 came from the First Baptist Church of Chattanooga, Tennessee--home church of our Pastor--which put us on top with \$50.00 to start a new building fund.

Yes, God has been good to us, and we thank Him for his marvelous grace and long suffering toward us. We have had our ups and downs, yes, but even as the children of Israel, when we followed close to the Lord, He could and did bless us. But many times we followed our own wills and went on before Him. Then the chastening hand humbled us again. May the next ten years see a lovely auditorium standing over the hole in the front of our property and many of our young people of today be filling places of responsibility in it for our Master's Glory.

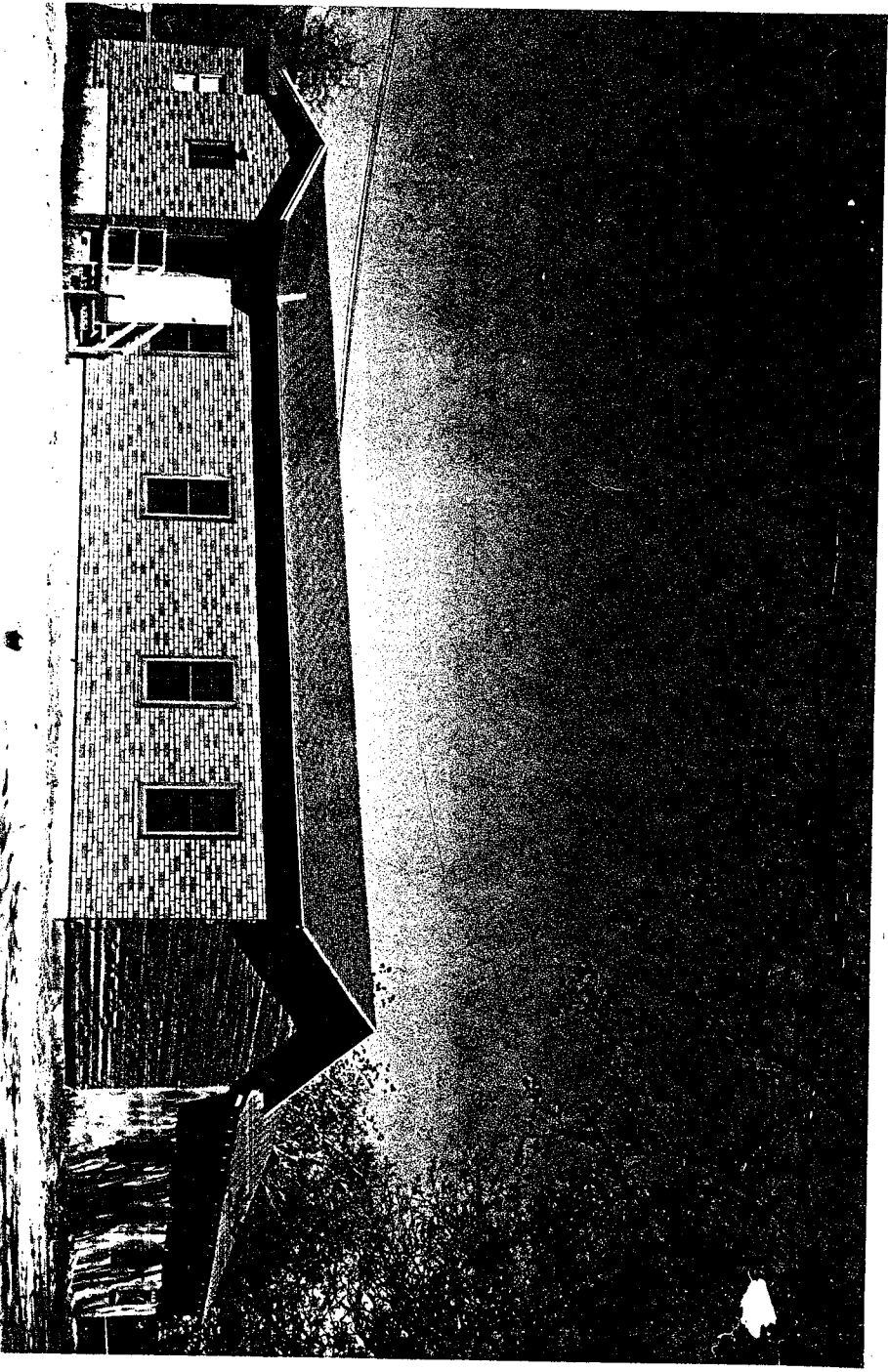
The meeting place of First Baptist Church in 1945.....
Originally the Odd Fellows Hall, then the Santa Fe Hotel
and presently the Talmarc Building



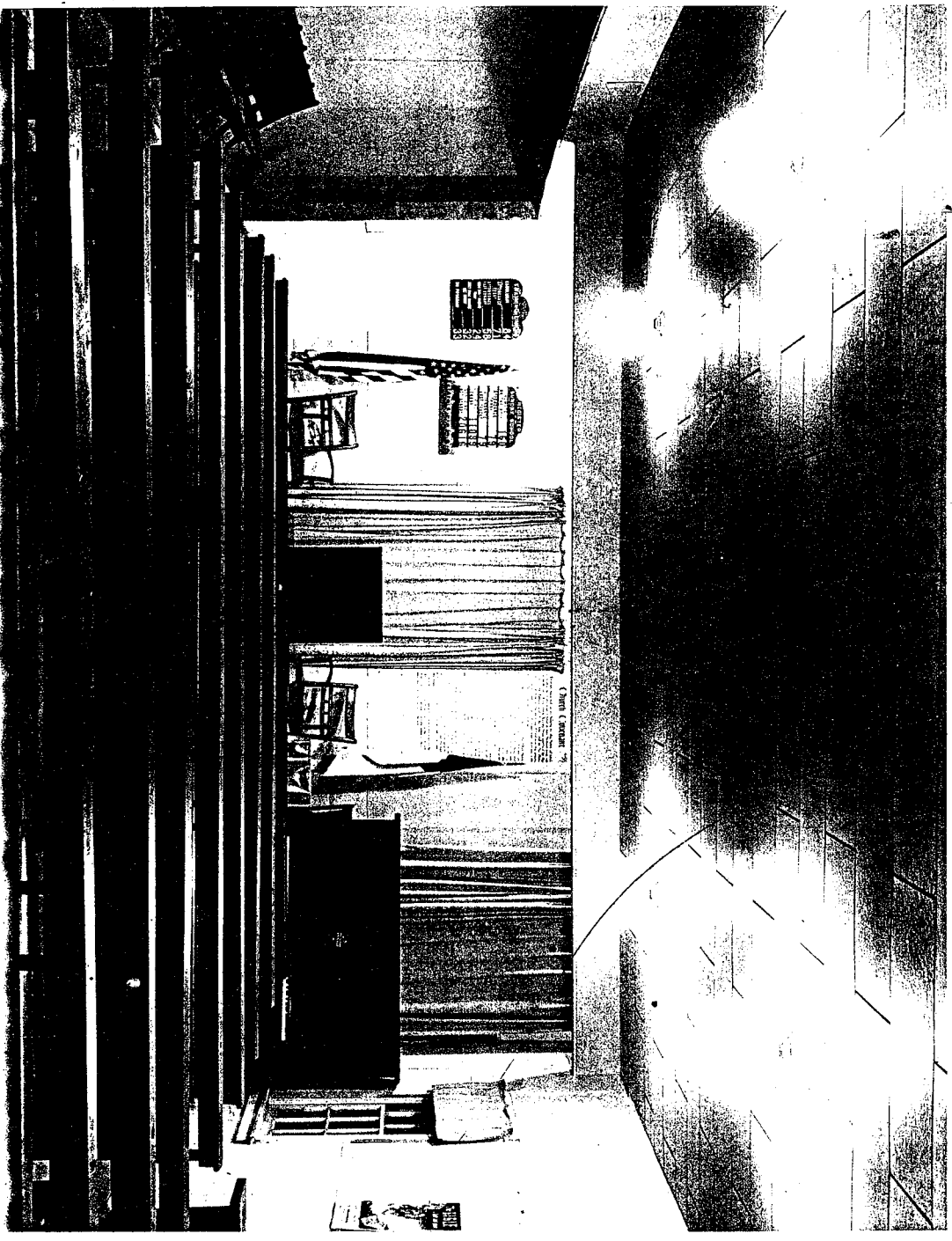
The first personage of the First Baptist Church
in 1946. It is still located on Curry.
Pastor and Mrs. Alexander and the Sunbeams in 1946



First Baptist Church Building in 1946
Moved to Tehachapi from Mansanar Prison
Camp near Lone Pine..

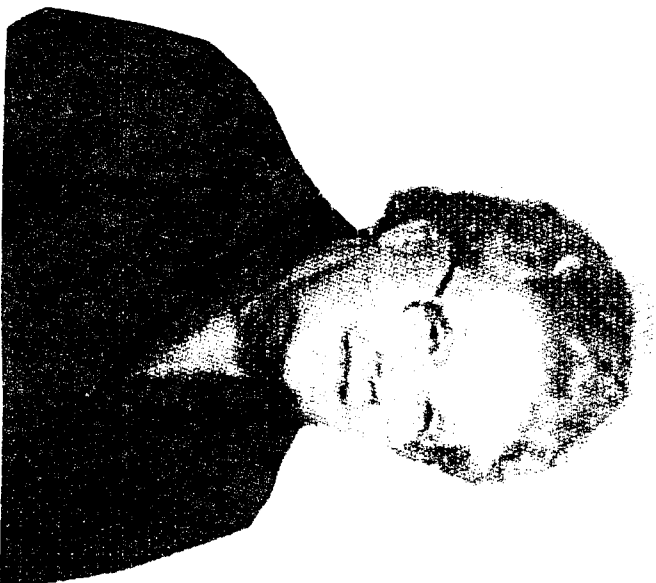


The inside view of the 1946 Church Building



THE GOLDEN YEARS - 1954-1988

By Ada Lee Sims



Brother R.M. Blackwood began his pastorate in February 1954. A new sanctuary was planned and partially constructed before his resignation in October 1955.

In November, 1955, Brother George Findley was called as pastor and served for seven years. During this time, the sanctuary was completed. A new pastorium was purchased and the old one was turned into Sunday School rooms. Adjoining property was acquired for Sunday School rooms.

Property on South Curry was purchased as a future church site. Upon Brother Findlay's resignation in February 1962, Brother Bert Edwards, our Area Missionary, served as interim pastor until June 1962 when Brother Keith Lloyd was called as pastor. He served until December 1964. Brother Sam Wilcoxon served as interim pastor until Brother Raymond Roberson was called on March 20, 1965. He moved onto the field April 26, 1965. During his seven year term the property at 414 South Curry was sold and the Sunday School plant was built on the property at 1049 South Curry Street, the present location of the church. The largest room was used as a sanctuary and the first services were held there on Easter Sunday, March 29, 1970 with 260 people attending.

Brother Roberson offered his resignation November 10, 1971, to move back to Tennessee to help his wife care for her invalid mother. On February 9, 1972, Brother Dexter Ogan was called as pastor and was with us almost eleven years. During this time a Bus Ministry was started. Religious Release Time for elementary school children was carried on in conjunction with other churches in town.

Children's Church was established in 1978. Beginning in September 1980, \$100,000 in church notes were sold. Plans and construction of our new sanctuary took almost a year and a half. The first worship service was held in the beautiful new sanctuary on February 21, 1982. Dedication was held on March 7th. The building and furnishings are completely debt free, including a fine audio system.

Brother Ogan presented his resignation December 5, 1982, and Brother Olin Collier served as interim pastor until Brother Phillip Neighbors of Granite, Oklahoma moved on the field June 1983.

During the time Brother Neighbors was pastor, the church experienced a surge of growth, and a new wing was built west of the existing buildings with six more Sunday School rooms and a section for Children's Church. Brother Mike Chaney from Broken Axe, Oklahoma was called as assistant pastor and moved on the field August 12, 1984.

Brother Olin Collier had moved to Buttonwillow to establish a mission there, sponsored by Temple Baptist Church in Bakersfield. We helped with this project financially for a time. In January 1985, the church voted to sponsor a mission point a Twin Oaks with Tom Allred in charge.

Barbara Sackett as hired as the pastor's secretary and a church office was officially opened September 8, 1983. We cooperated with the Association in the acquisition of Skyview Christian Camp in the Tehachapi Mountains.

Both Brother Neighbors and Brother Chaney resigned as of December 5, 1985. Brother collier was again elected as interim pastor. Tom Allred was licensed to preach in January 1986.

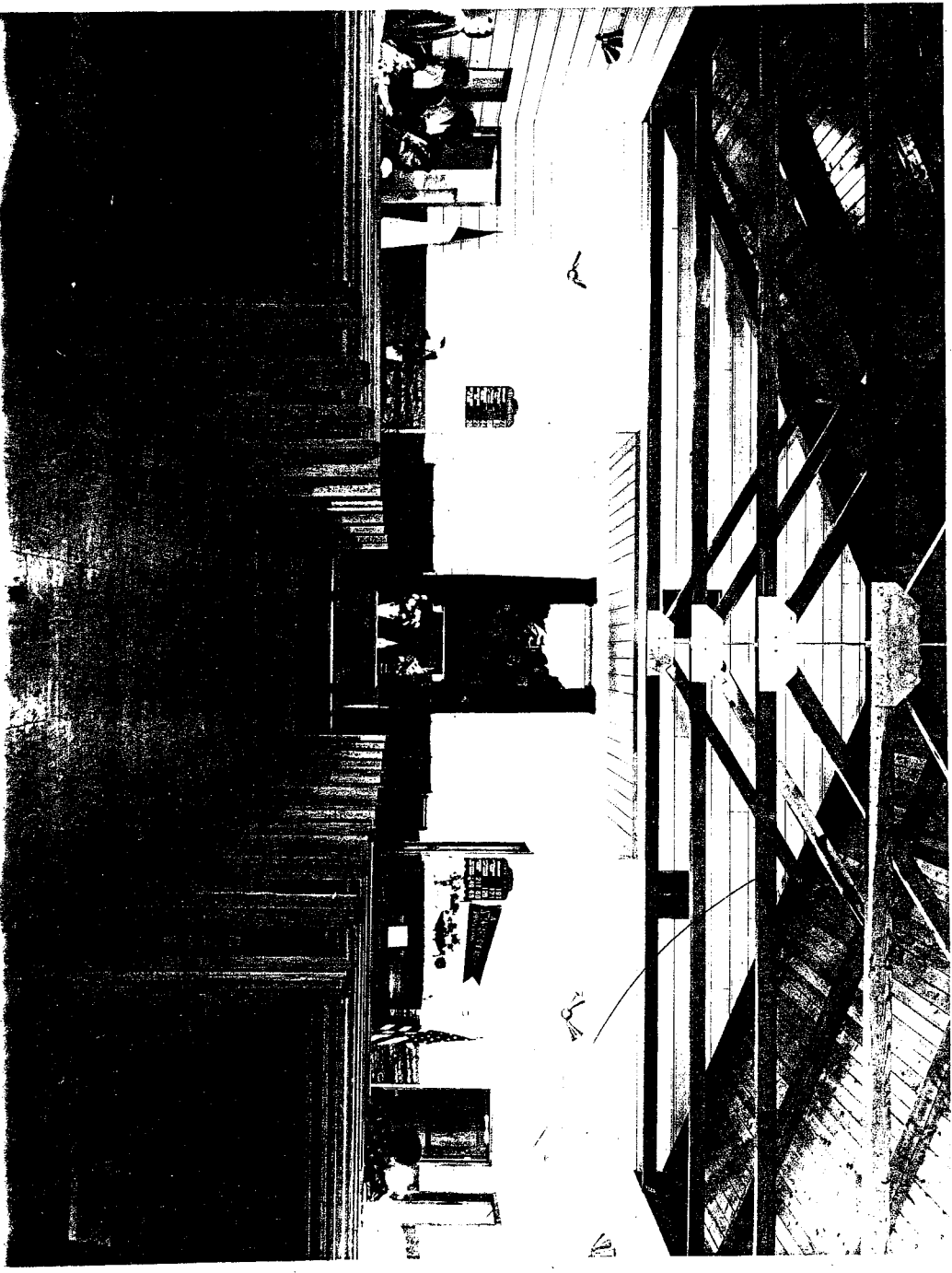
Brother James Trammell of Bakersfield was called as pastor on March 2, 1986, and began his ministry Palm Sunday, March 19. In September the AWMANA program was started. In December, Brian Kaiser was called as full-time Minister of Youth and Music. He began his ministry January 1, 1987. During 1987, the Media Center was established and participation in BTN begun.

On February 10, 1988, Brother Trammell and Brian Kaiser resigned in order to establish a mission point in the Golden Hills Community. Approximately half of the congregation joined them and the First Baptist Church underwent a reorganization program.

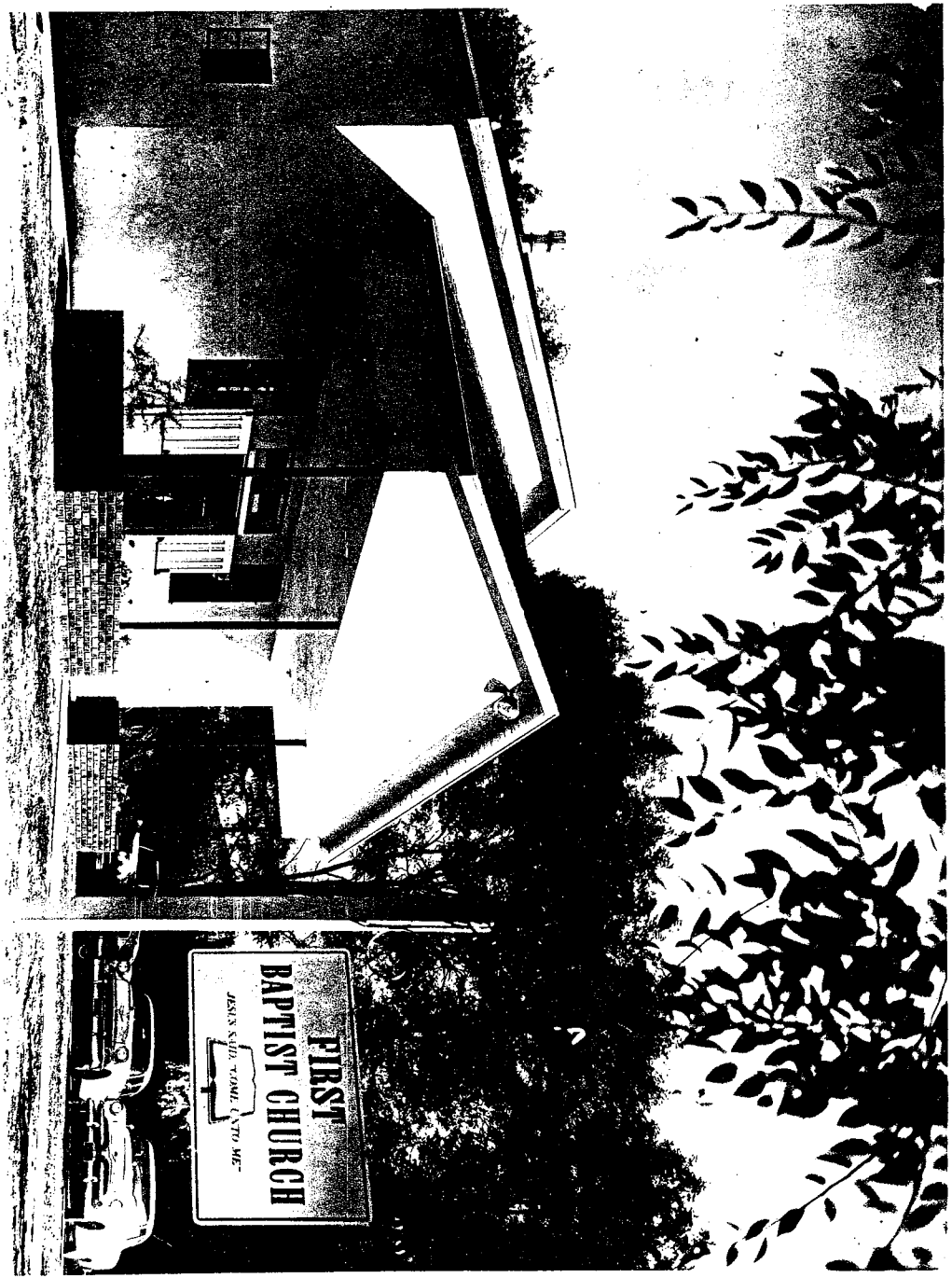
On July 24, 1988, Brother Jerry McCullah of Bakersfield was called as interim pastor, and as permanent pastor October 5th.

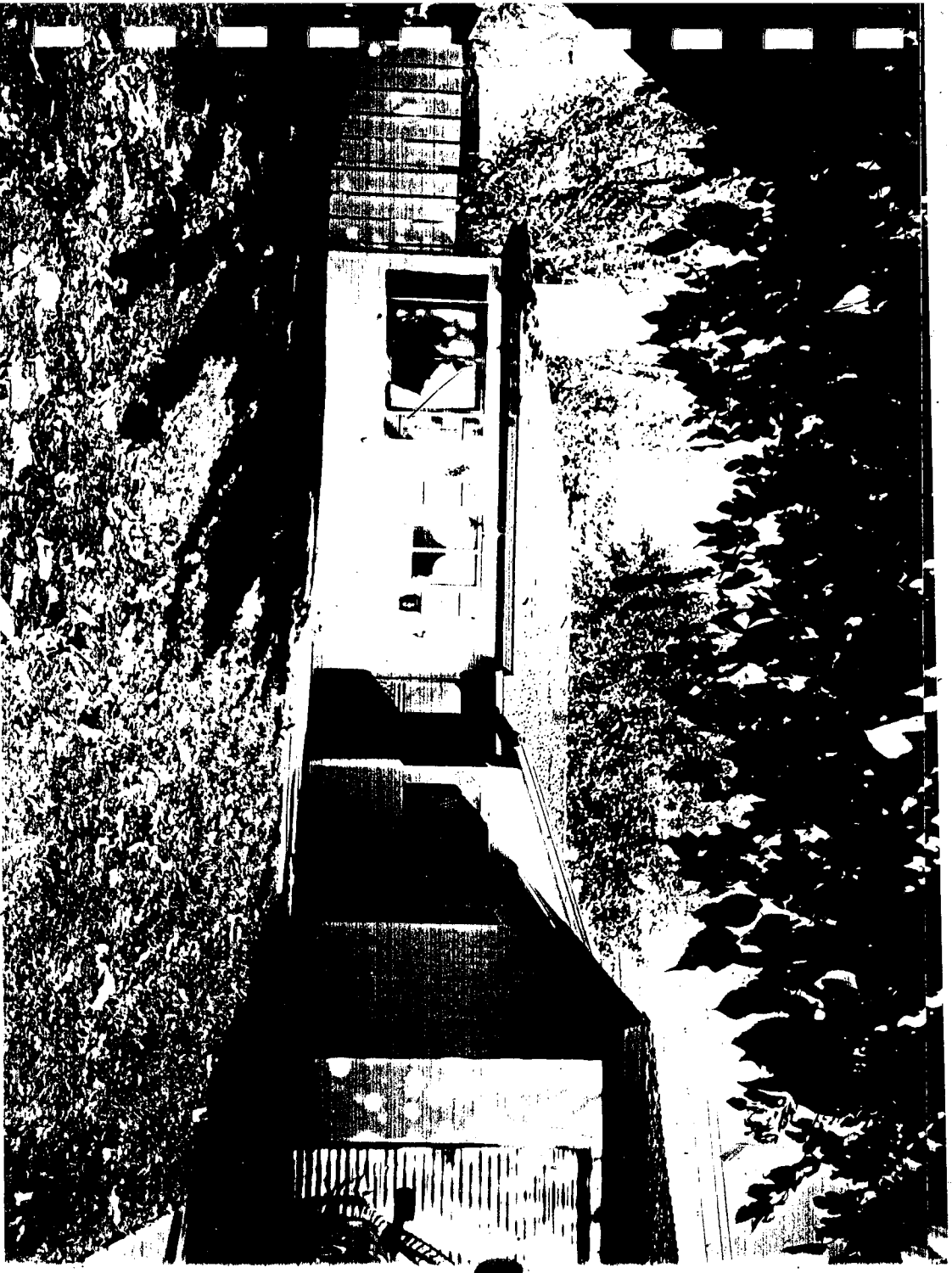
There are still six of the original twelve charter members serving our Lord in an active capacity: Mr. and Mrs. Olin Collier, Mr. and Mrs. George Johnson and Mr. and Mrs. Everett Sims.

The inside View of the First Baptist Church Building in
1956



The First Baptist Church Building on Curry Street
in 1956





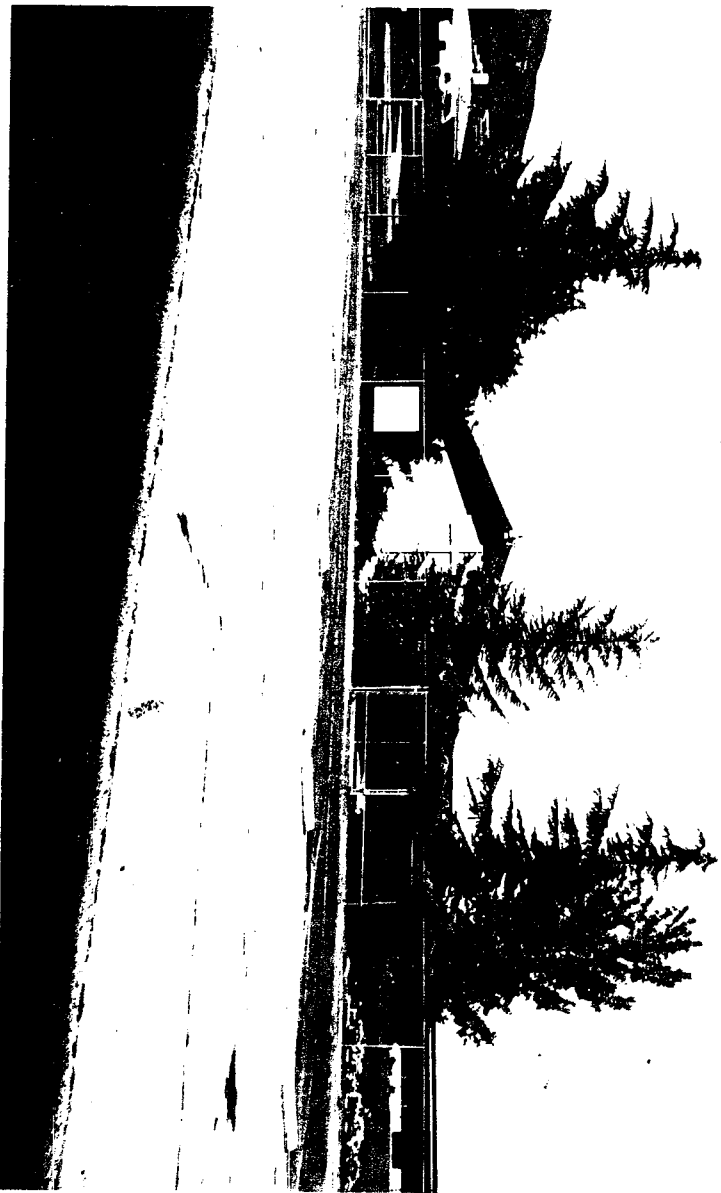
The second parsonage
purchased in 1959
located on Bamboo Ct

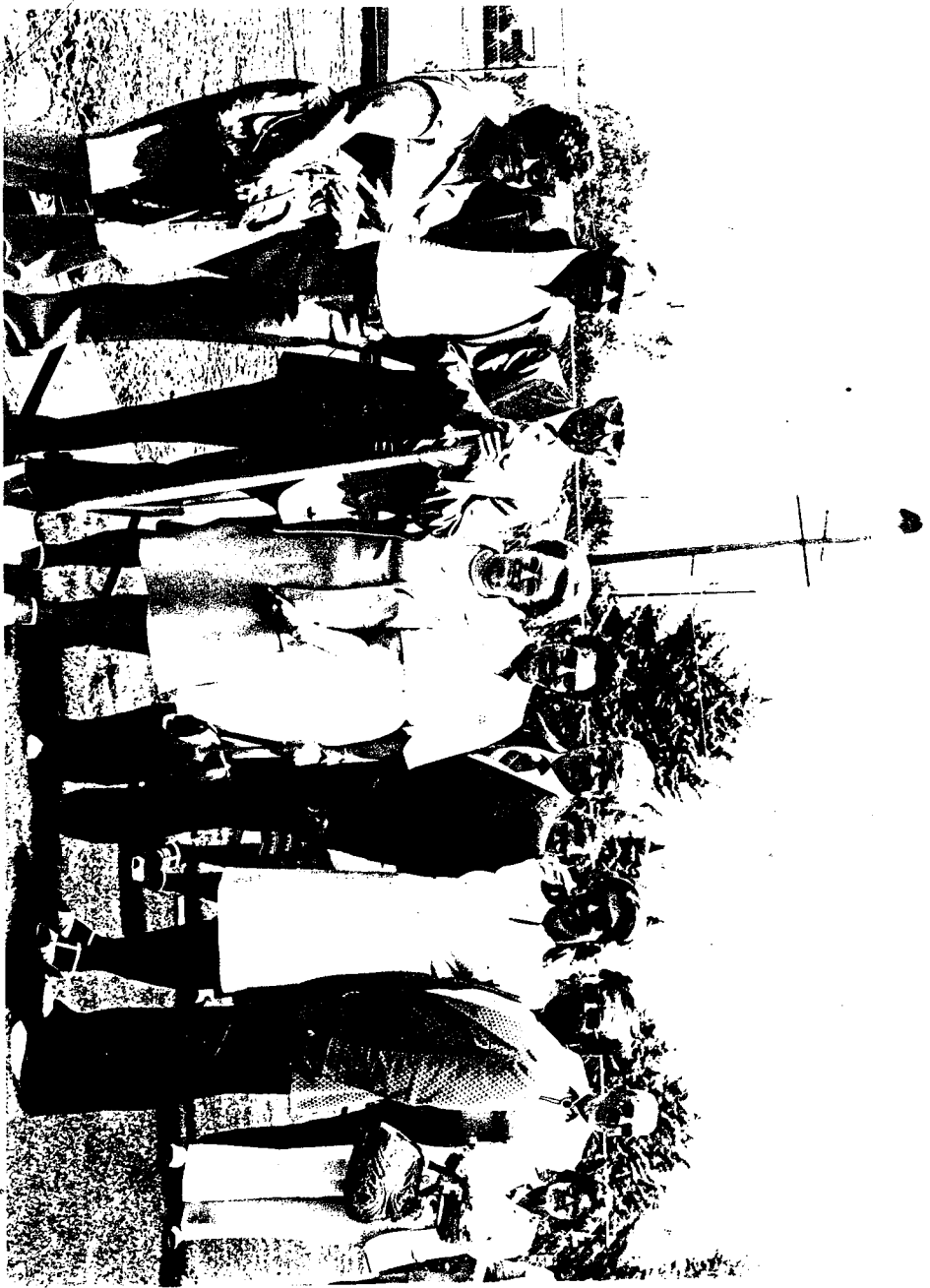
The Dowdy House
Purchased in 1959
located at Curry
and street



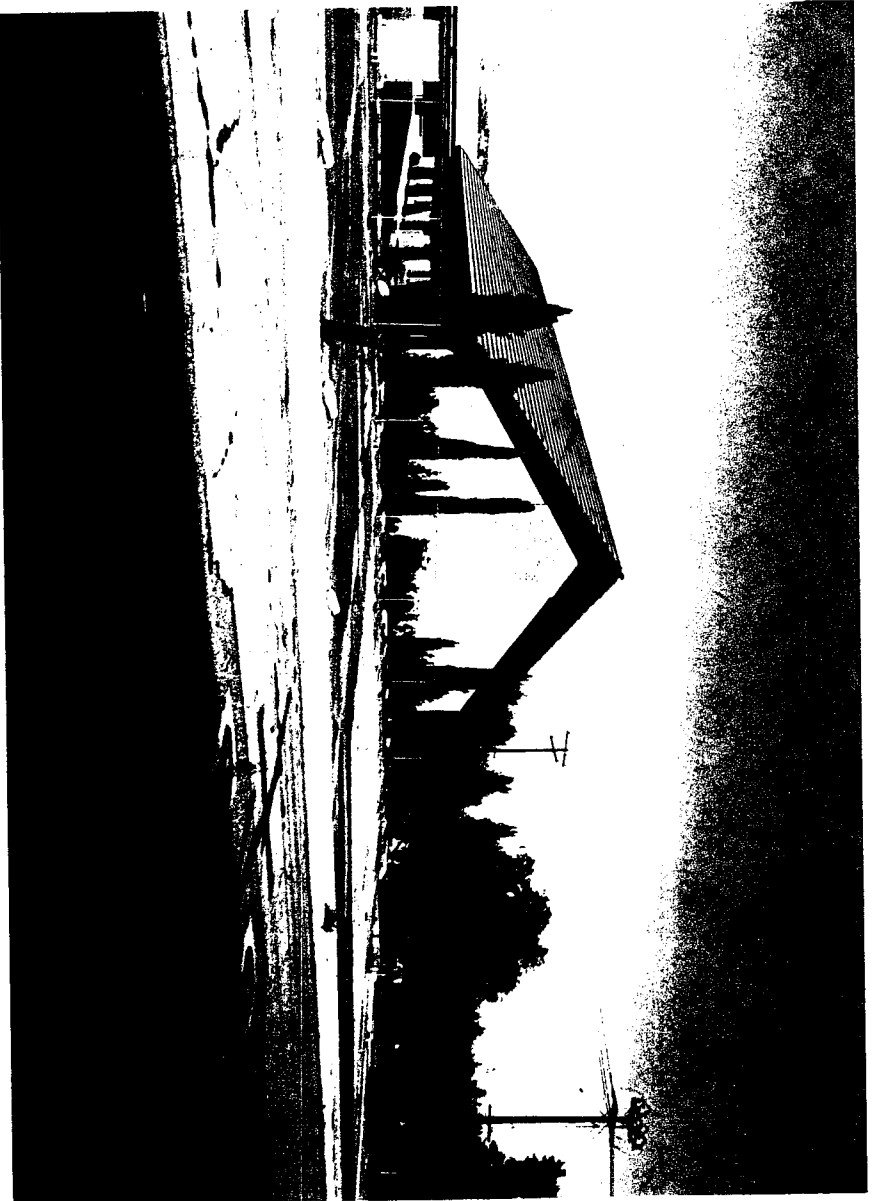


1967 ground breaking at 1049
south Curry for the new buildings
finished in 1970.



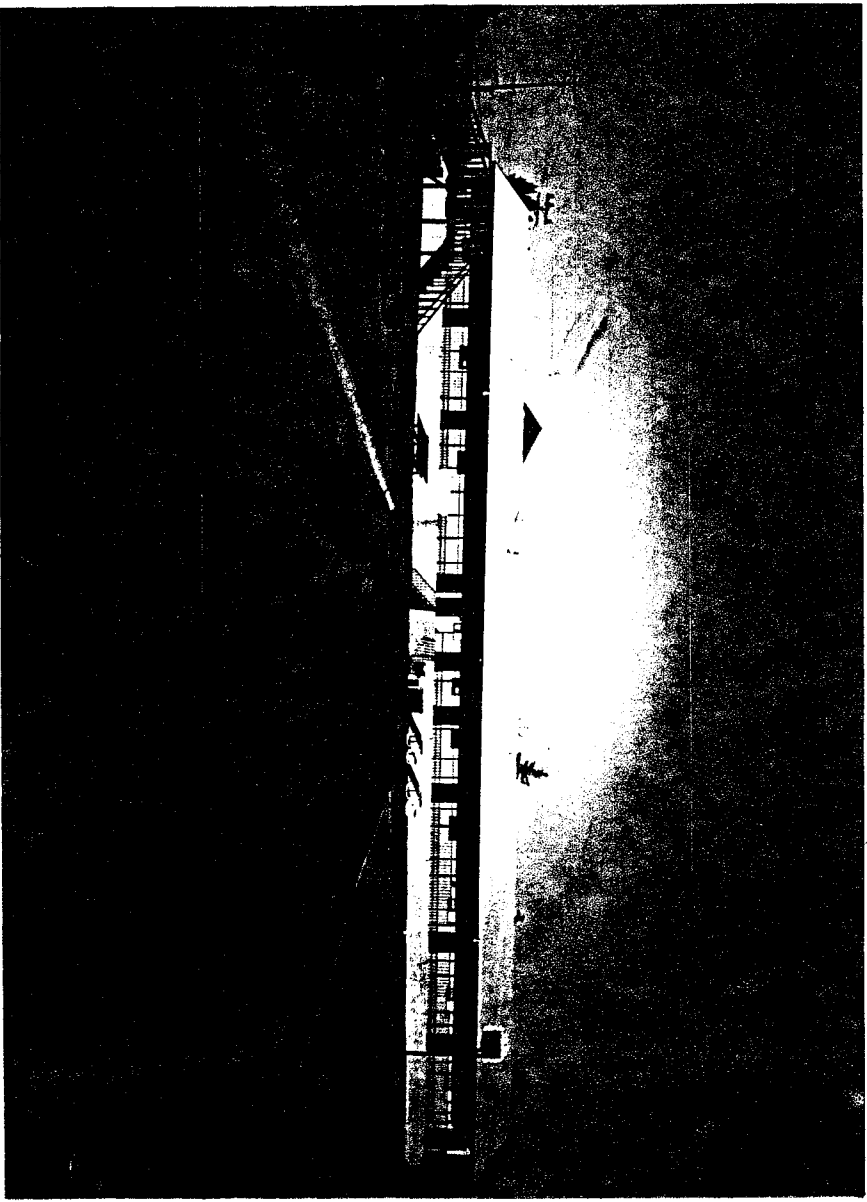


1981 ground breaking at 1049 South Curry
for new Sanctuary finished in 1982





Ground Breaking for new
Educational Building 1984
New Building Below



THE RECENT YEARS - 1988-1992

By Harry B. Jasper



October 12, 1988, First Baptist Church of Tehachapi called a new pastor, Brother Jerry McCullah, from North Heights Baptist Church in Oildale, California (Oildale is a part of Bakersfield, California). Brother McCullah was the Education Coordinator there and was waiting for a position as pastor.

On December 14, 1988, a new Constitution was adopted in order to gain more direction and organization. The Constitutional Committee was made up of Chairman, Lon Sackett, Esther Winterrowd, Diana Belles and Ernie Dunn.

The next years were marked by a struggle with membership and finances. A Sunday School attendance dropped to an average of 65. Worship attendance was about 90 - 100 people and monthly revenues were below our expenditures.

The Church ordained Tom Allred, March 22, 1992. Tom continues to pastor the mission at Twin Oaks with an attendance of 45-50.

In February of 1992, the fellowship voted to support a second mission. A Spanish mission was started and meets in the adult Sunday School wing of the Church building. Ruben Viveros from Ventura, California led two Spanish families to the Lord. He decided to start a church where they could grow and serve. They were invited to hold church in our facilities. They have an average attendance of 30-40 members.

The Deacon Body had been stocking a food pantry for the last couple of years and increasing Thanksgiving and Christmas food baskets. In November of 1991, six baskets were given for Thanksgiving and six more for Christmas. In November of

1992, seven baskets were delivered for Thanksgiving. This ministry gave rise to hosting a food share program.

On December 11, 1991, the First Baptist Church voted to be a host for the Share Program. People pay \$14.00 a share for \$50-\$60 worth of food. A group from the Church, once a month, leave early on Saturday morning to go to Apple Valley and return with the shares. We usually have from 60-100 or more shares, and people come about 10:00 A.M. to 12:00 noon to pick them up. We have provided good food to many people for low prices.

In September of 1992, another ministry was re-established. Men's Ministry, formerly called Brotherhood, was started to meet some of the physical and spiritual needs of people in our fellowship and/or community. They meet every second Saturday. Ron Palmer is Chairman, Ernie Dunn is Treasurer and Harry Jasper is Recorder.

May 17-18, 1991, there was a different kind of rally at the First Baptist Church. Wayne Henderson of the Christian Motorcyclist Association, brought their rally to Tehachapi and asked to use our facilities. May of our own members attended their meetings. They stayed to participate in our Sunday worship service. In the evening service, Brother Henderson presented a CMA program to let us know about their ministry.

In August of 1990, First Baptist Church allowed the Tehachapi Christian School to use our buildings for their school for ten months. The school is still meeting in our building as of December 1992.

During 1992, our Deacon Body has increased to eleven active deacons. According to the new Constitution, when the number of deacons reaches nine, a rotation system will be started. Following what was agreed to, the Deacons rotated two deacons off for the year: Brother Clyde Skidmore and Brother Olin Collier. This left nine active deacons: Ed Patterson, Lon Sackett, Dean Wachtner, Coy Blair, Everett Sims, Berlie Wright, Harry Jasper, Les Gooding and Riley Hutson. Also on the inactive list is Jim Nobles.

November 3, 1991, plans for a Fiftieth Anniversary Celebration were put in motion. The anniversary committee, made up of Harry Jasper, Darlene Jasper, Ada Lee Sims, Barbara Sackett, Polly Collier and Lorene Sanders, has been working and planning for a December 6, 1992, celebration. As we approach this Fiftieth Anniversary, attendance is up, the financial situation is looking better, giving to missions has remained high (3rd highest in the Association), food has been provided for others and witnessing to the lost is on the increase.

We pray that we will have fifty more years of successful service for our Lord. Brother Jerry says it marks fifty years closer to our Lord's coming. But however you look at it, we praise the Lord or his love and blessings; for giving us this fellowship and the buildings so we can minister to the physical and spiritual needs of the people in this community.

INTERESTING FACTS AND EVENTS FIRST BAPTIST CHURCH

1. The first pastor, Dick Loving, was paid only \$10 a week.
2. Childrens Church was started by the Youth Department in March of 1975.
3. Nathan Ogan, now pastor of Easton Baptist Church, was the first preacher of Childrens Church.
4. First Baptist Church baptisms were held in the Tehachapi Valley Recreation and Parks District swimming pool from 1978-1982.
5. The first parsonage, built in 1946 was made from lumber taken from Mansanar, a Japanese concentration camp, located near Lone Pine, California.
6. First Baptist Church was started by several women that organized a WMU (Woman's Missionary Union).
7. The church building from 1946-1957 had the baptistry under the pulpit.
8. Our church is third in the Association for giving to the Cooperative Program.
9. In the summer of 1992, we were the only Church in Tehachapi that held Vacation Bible School.
10. Eddie Parks, grandson of Ada Lee McLaughlin, was baptized in Patty and Grant Snyder's outdoor swimming pool while it was snowing.
11. The first Lottie Moon offering was \$2.50.
12. In 1942, the First Baptist Church met in a bar and had to clean up before Sunday morning services.
13. Shad Aldrich was the first person baptized in the new sanctuary on March 7, 1982.
14. The first offering taken was for the cooperative program and was \$4.41.
15. The pastor could not rent a house in Tehachapi in the early forties because the town had the Catholic Church, the Community Church, the Four Square Gospel Church (now Apostolic Church) and they thought that was enough. Only when the pastor took a mechanic job would people rent to him.
16. In 1942, the Church met in members' homes. Again in 1945, First Baptist Church met in the homes of members.